



▲ WESTERN FRONT

For most of the war in Western Europe, fighting was deadlocked along a 440-mile (700-km) strip of land that ran from the North Sea south through Belgium and France called the Western Front. Both sides dug deep trenches along the frontier to defend themselves against bombardment.

▼ TANK WARFARE

Tanks were a new weapon of war developed by Britain and France during World War I. They helped troops cross rubble-covered battle grounds and enemy trenches, and could resist light gunfire and shrapnel from exploding shells.



World War I

When war broke out in Europe in 1914, European colonies across the world were soon dragged into the conflict. The results were catastrophic. Over the next four years, towns and cities were destroyed, and national economies were wrecked. By the war's end, more than 20 million people had died.

The origins of the war lay in the two rival alliances that divided Europe: the Central Powers, led by Austria-Hungary and Germany, and the Allies, led by Russia, France, and Britain. In June 1914, a Serbian revolutionary assassinated Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne. Austria-Hungary blamed the Serbian government for the attack and declared war, prompting Russia to come to Serbia's aid. Germany then declared war on Russia and France. Germany then invaded

Belgium, bringing Britain, which had promised to protect Belgium, into the conflict.

Fighting took place mainly in Europe, but also spread to Africa and Asia. Both France and Britain drew on their colonial empires for troops, many of whom were Asian or Black. For a long time, the war was at a stalemate, with massive casualties in battles that only achieved tiny advances. This changed in 1917 when the US joined the Allies. When the conflict ended in November 1918, it was said to be the "war to end all wars."